

Session Twelve (Conflict Management)



Management

What is conflict?

- A state of *incompatibility* of ideas between two or more parties or individuals.
- It is an *inevitable part* of human existence, either in organizational life or in one's personal life.
- Conflict may be occurred between two individuals, as in the case of superior vs. subordinate, husband vs. wife, housewife vs. tenant, etc.

Reactions to intense conflict situations

Psychological Responses

- ❖ Inattentiveness to other things
- ❖ Lack of interest in work
- ❖ Job dissatisfaction
- ❖ Isolation from others
- ❖ Frustration

Behavioural Responses

- ❖ Excessive smoking
- ❖ Alcoholism
- ❖ Under-eating or overeating
- ❖ Aggression towards others or work interruption
- ❖ Decreased communication

Physiological response

- ❖ Psychosomatic disorders such as-
- ❖ Breathing problems such as asthma
- ❖ Hypertension
- ❖ Headaches

Functional aspects/Beneficial Consequences of conflict

When properly managed, conflict can have beneficial consequences. They can-

- Motivate individuals to do better and to work harder.
- Provide creative, constructive, and innovative ideas (For example; *employee benefits today are the outcome of the union-management conflicts over the past decades*)
- Facilitating an understanding of the problem, people, and interrelationship between people, better condition among individuals and departments.

Types of conflict

- Inter-personal and intra-personal
- Inter-group and intra-group
- Competitive and Disruptive

All of the types are discussed in the next following slides

Inter-personal and intra-personal

- **Interpersonal conflict** refers to a disagreement between two people. The main cause of the interpersonal conflict is the difference between individuals. People always have differences, based on their attitudes, beliefs, culture and values. Furthermore, they have their own set of goals, expectations, personalities and perceptions, which lead to conflicts.
- **Intrapersonal conflict** refers to a disagreement within an individual, which is caused by one's own actions, emotions, beliefs and values. In other words, it is a psychological involvement that occurs within you. Sometimes, it is a conflict between should and wants. Here, should is always driven by values and believes while a want is driven by the environment.

Individual Conflict

- ✓ **Interpersonal conflict:**
 - between two or more people a differences in views about what should be done
 - differences in orientation to work and time in different parts of an organization
- ✓ **Intrapersonal conflict:**
 - occurs within an individual
 - threat to a person's values
 - feeding of unfair treatment
 - multiple and contradictory sources of socialization

Inter-group and intra-group

- **Intergroup conflict** refers to a disagreement between two or more groups. Different groups of people interrelate to operate a business and to accomplish organizational objective and goals. Thus, this interrelation can lead to conflicts between groups of people. For instance, the sales team of a company may have a dispute with the technical team about a new product launch.
- **Intragroup conflict** refers to a disagreement between members of a group who shares common targets, interests or other identifying features. Intragroup conflicts may occur in workplaces, and this can be considered as small-scale. When conflicts occur within a specific population group, it is large scale conflicts.



Competitive/Constructive and Disruptive Conflicts

- A conflict is usually viewed as something negative, as it generates a lot of frustration between the parties involved. However, a conflict does not necessarily have to be destructive. In a constructive conflict, even though, a disagreement between two parties emerges, this can be **resolved in a positive manner so that it benefits both parties. This is often referred to as a win-win situation** because both parties benefit from it.
- Unlike a constructive conflict, a destructive conflict is characterized by **feelings of frustration**. Destructive conflicts do not bring about positive outcomes and damages the productivity of an organization. In such a situation, both parties make an effort to win at whatever cost.

Conflict Resolution

- Conflict resolution is conceptualized as the **methods and processes involved in facilitating the peaceful ending of conflict**. Committed group members attempt to resolve group conflicts by actively communicating information about their conflicting motives or ideologies to the rest of group (e.g., intentions; reasons for holding certain beliefs) and by engaging in collective negotiation.



Negotiation

- The process of bargaining between two or more parties to reach a solution that is mutually acceptable

Stages in the Negotiation Process (Both Parties)

- Preparation
- Relationship-Building
- Information Exchange
- Persuasion
- Agreement



The Negotiation Process

Distributive Negotiation (Win-Lose)

Integrative Negotiation (Win-Win)

Distributive Negotiation

- **Distributive negotiation (Win-Lose)**
 - Parties perceive that they have a “fixed pie” of resources that they need to divide
 - See no need to interact in the future
 - Do not care if their interpersonal relationship is damaged by their competitive negotiation

Integrative Negotiation (Win-Win)

- **Integrative bargaining**

- Parties perceive that they might be able to increase the resource pie by trying to come up with a creative solution to the conflict
- View the conflict as a win-win situation in which both parties can gain
- Handled through collaboration or compromise

Conflict Management Strategies

- **Compromise**

- each party is concerned about their goal accomplishment and is willing to engage in give-and-take exchange to reach a reasonable solution.

- **Collaboration**

- parties try to handle the conflict without making concessions by coming up with a new way to resolve their differences.

Conflict Management Strategies

- **Accommodation**
 - one party simply gives in to the other party
- **Avoidance**
 - two parties try to ignore the problem and do nothing to resolve the disagreement